

SPORTS DAY

JOE CAMERON

Joe Cameron is a 26 year old writer from Glasgow, Scotland. His work focuses on memories, home and family. He hopes to remind readers of the importance of reflecting on who we are and how we came to be here.

A thumping came from his tiny chest. They were all watching. It was his chance to prove himself. Once a year, that was all he got. He looked around at his opponents and his stomach began to sing. His father had told him to breathe deeply before the race, yet the advice felt absurd in the heat of battle. He looked to his feet—plimsolls stained with red ash and white paint. Time to make sure he was behind the start line. No false starts this year. Heart in his throat, a voice from above counted down from three. One last glance around the playground. Eggs and spoons, skipping ropes, potato sacks. He scoffed—how childish. This was a man’s game, and he would show mummy and daddy just how manly he was.

Go. The ground beneath his soles gave way as he pushed off and the herd of children began to gallop. His mother had told him to run and not look back. Forward, always forward. The wind against his face freed him from nerves. He was at the front—he was sure of it. He would win. Confidence rushed through him as his gangly strides became fluid, certain. A man amongst boys. A wolf amongst sheep. Yes, he would win, and win in style. How easy it was to be first in your field.

Halfway to the finish line, his energy seemed to grow. In a moment of arrogance, he turned his head to see how far ahead he was—and found another runner beside him. His rival breathed heavily, stomping the gravel. He could not lose now. He threw his weight into every stride before tragedy turned its eye to him. With twenty yards to go, his left ankle struck his right calf. He catapulted through the thick summer air, his insides vanishing before he hit the ground. His legs scrambled for balance. It was no use. His face skidded across the red dirt and his body followed.

Facedown in his misery, he dared not look up. Tears darkened the ground beneath his bruised face. Pity from parents, laughter from children. He turned over, head in his palms, shoulders shaking. Footsteps approached. Two arms encircled him. His mother’s voice. Suddenly, his injuries were mended and his tiny ego forgotten. He was shielded from the world, its noise gone.

“Don’t worry, darling. There’s always next year.”

EVERY DECISION, EVERY GRAIN OF SAND

JOE CAMERON

Time seems to threaten me. I cannot breathe below its weight, it crushes me with every passing day. The inevitability of tomorrow terrifies me, and forces me down a path I would rather not tread. But I must, for when I look back I cannot see my origin. All I see behind me is air muddled by decisions made during a lifetime of yesterdays, decisions which have led me to exactly here- today. So now I tread wearily down this narrow path of my own making, towards my certain demise. All that lies ahead of me is dull grey, for I refused the colourful path which held at its end my dreams. There may well be a correct way to live, it is certainly not this way. Choose wisely and choose the option that sparks your whimsy. Otherwise you shall be applauded by the other grey people on their own straight little paths, for you made the same decision as them, and they made the same decision as you. Thus, it must have been the right one. Well, what if it wasn’t?

77 68 61

74 27 73

20 60 65

66 74 3F

no

you don't understand

I can't just snap out of it

it's not like a light switch

or a button to be pushed

my mind is a tangled mess

of voices and thoughts

all jumbled together

like a pile of yarn

knotted and twisted

impossible to unravel

I can't tell what's real

and what's not

what's mine

and what's theirs

their whispers fill my head

and I can't make them stop

they tell me I'm worthless

a burden

better off dead

and sometimes I believe them

I try to fight back

but it's like swimming against a
current

exhausting and futile

so I retreat

into my own world

where it's safe

and quiet

and I can pretend

for a little while

that I'm okay

that I'm normal

but then the voices return

screaming and taunting

tearing me apart

until I'm nothing

but a broken mind

trapped in a broken body

and all I can do

THE GHOST OF WHO I WAS

UWAIZ MUHAMMAD

"When Echoes from the past draw near,
their voices faint, yet crystal clear, they call
for him the boy they knew, a fleeting
shadow, a distant hue. He lingers still, a
ghostly trace, in memories, in time's
embrace. But I am not him, though we share
a name, the forge of life has changed my
frame. They seek the fire, the reckless
stride, the boy who ran, no thought to hide.
But years have weathered these bones
since then, I am not who I was back when.
Oh, let him rest, that restless soul, who
chased the wind but lacked the whole. For
though he's gone, his echoes stay, to guide
me through the darker grey. So when they
call I softly grieve, for all he was, I still
believe. But time has carved a different man
and I am not who they think I am."

UWAIZ IS A 23-YEAR-OLD ARCHITECTURE GRADUATE WHO DISCOVERED A PASSION FOR POETRY THROUGH PERSONAL LOSS. INITIALLY UNFAMILIAR WITH THE ART FORM, UWAIZ TURNED TO JOURNALING AS A REFUGE AFTER EXPERIENCING THE LOSS OF SEVERAL FRIENDS AND FAMILY MEMBERS IN VARIOUS WAYS. THIS REFLECTIVE PRACTICE GRADUALLY EVOLVED INTO WRITING POETRY, WHICH UWAIZ NOW CREATES AS A PERSONAL ENDEAVOR. THROUGH THE MEDIUM OF POETRY, UWAIZ AIMS TO COMMUNICATE THE MESSAGE THAT CHANGE, THOUGH OFTEN CHALLENGING, IS BOTH INEVITABLE AND ACCEPTABLE.

MELIA G. STERN (SHE/HER) IS A POET BASED IN
SAN DIEGO, CALIFORNIA, ORIGINALLY FROM
MARYLAND. AFTER MORE THAN A DECADE
WORKING IN THE CORPORATE WORLD, SHE
RETURNED TO WRITING FOLLOWING THE DEATH
OF HER FATHER — A LOSS THAT REIGNITED HER
CREATIVE LIFE. HER POETRY OFTEN EXPLORES
GRIEF, LOVE, WOMANHOOD, RELATIONSHIPS, HER
DOG, AND THE QUIET WORK OF FALLING IN LOVE
AGAIN WITH THE WORLD. SHE IS A MEMBER OF
THE GATHER POETS COMMUNITY, AND HER WORK
CAN BE FOUND ON INSTAGRAM @STUPWORDS.

MELIA G. STERN



IT'S EASIER IF WE USE METAPHORS

I read somewhere that grief was like butter
rigid, unimpressonable at first
and then slowly softening, folding in
like my heart were a croissant
and the sadness added extra flavor
instead of ruining my taste.
A friend told me my brain was a computer
reprogramming itself, playing back bits of code
trying to right the bug that made it wrong.
It's an old injury that flares up from time to time,
a heavy backpack glued to my shoulders,
being engulfed in waves and gasping for air,
or at least some people see it like this.
To me, it is finishing the last chapter
of the last book in a beloved series,
the ending rushed and abrupt
(the author forced to finish on a deadline)
and realizing all I will ever have
is the pages I've already read.

SUDDENLY WE WERE SUNFLOWERS

We told ourselves this love was temporary.
Fiercely I flipped through your pages
like a library book I needed to return.
At night, I held you and whispered my dreams
for you in your ears:
a big house with a backyard
a couple of kids who adored you
a love you didn't need to question
On the day we said goodbye
I kissed your forehead, softly
mourning unmade memories.
I thought I was drowning
plucked prematurely and drenched, destined
to rot in the void,
but that's the thing about us ephemeral creatures:
pain is never permanent.
You left behind a trail of seeds.
Grounded in darkness I clutched at the sky
grasping sunbeams in outstretched arms.
I hung a new calendar, the days grew longer.
I found someone else to love,
whispered dreams in his ears.
I told him about you -
how you opened a space in my heart for him.
One morning I awoke with dry eyes, emerging
to find myself in a field of sunflowers.
Everywhere I looked was yellow,
hundreds of petals nourished
by the love we shared.
I never expected you to stay with me forever,
but you planted roots like tattoos in my skin
and made me your home.

I LEARNED TO GRIEVE LIKE I LEARNED TO RUN

At first, I just wanted to get it over with
so I'd sprint until a stitch spliced through my side, pause
every few minutes to catch my breath, face flushed
legs leaden with loathing.
I hate this I hate this I hate this.

And so I tried again
slipped on my sneakers
and told myself
to take it one step
at a time, my heavy
feet pounding
on the pavement,
slowly shuffling
through short slogs
that felt like
marathons.
Keep going keep going keep going.

For a little while, I was running every day. A 10K here, four miles there, a quick
jog after work, no choice and no excuses. I was tracking each daunting distance,
cradling tight calves and bruised toes like race medals, coaching and coaxing
myself through, with every run readjusting the bar of what I could endure.

Let's do this let's do this. Let's do this

Now I'm feeling faster, relishing
in the community of run clubs,
finally capable of talking while
my body bounds steadily forward.
Sometimes I think it even looks
easy for me, barely breaking a sweat.
I admit: with practice, I've become
a stronger woman, but still, my aching
and perspired heart taunts me:
I hate this I hate this I hate this.

ALEX DAWSON IS A WRITER, MOM, WILDLIFE PHOTOGRAPHER AND ESL TEACHER FROM TORONTO. SHE RECENTLY PUBLISHED A NATURE FACT POETRY ANTHOLOGY, ENTITLED, “UPON LEARNING THAT”, WHICH REACHED #1 IN POETRY ANTHOLOGIES ON AMAZON. SHE PUBLISHED HER PHOTO-POETRY BOOK, “ALL THESE LIVING THINGS” IN THE SUMMER OF 2024. ALEX HAS ALSO BEEN PUBLISHED BY “THE QUEEN’S QUARTERLY”, “THE BOMBAY LITERARY REVIEW”, “TURNING LEAF JOURNAL”, “LIVINA PRESS” AND “GATHER POETS”. SHE WRITES WITH CONSTANT CURIOSITY AND A DESIRE TO EXAMINE THE THREADS OF CONNECTION BETWEEN NATURE, CULTURE AND IDENTITY. ALEX CAN BE FOUND ON INSTAGRAM AND SUBSTACK @ALEXDAWCREATES.

A NIGHTMARE OR A DREAM



The truth is I discovered her
when I had already been bloodied,
when I had already been broken
like an arrow, I discovered her,
in the forest, in the cradle
of my mind, she was walking,
in all white, like a bride
of the moon, I discovered
her, I had loved her all my life,
I had begged her, all my life,
to come forward, to blossom
in a land with no water.
How does anything blossom
in a land with no water?
She laughed, then she became
one thousand mirrors. If there
is no water, she said, then you
must become the rain.

ALEX DAWSON



CORONER

ALEX DAWSON

The night comes
silent and scolding
and here I am
at 3 am-
eyes peeled open
like wild grapes.
Thinking about
how many quarters
I need for laundry
and who killed
Michael Jackson-
or did he die of
natural causes?
And all the while
the moon is
stalking me outside.
Suddenly I picture
myself ethereal.
Wrapped in a
gown of white
linen. Or maybe
just something
half decent, for
the coroner to
cover me with.



CATFISH

CATCH

TIME

Gregory, pull a fast one. Rip the hairy honey suckle from the wilting vine. If I'm getting older, let's skip to the part where I regain sexual innocence and the slimy, fermented filth finally crusts and falls. Tell the miser to keep the gold. Today I'll let the dandelions invade my body, penetrate the shell. If only to be perceived as flossy. I'll pretend that choosing the feminine is my very first nature and eagerly swim to my sisters on the shore. Where diamond rings splinter and icy snowflakes abound. I want you to tell me my eyes aren't brown, they're instant coffee. Immediately yours when you are wan, unable to sleep again, grimacing through another dawn.

ABOUT

MARCHING

SONGS

Scream let them answer the call
Draw them in draw them in
Born to dance born to march
Born to run with ye all
Am I bewitched or am I happy
Am I brainwashed or am I ready
Was I born to dance born to march?
I was born to run with ye all
Stomp, move your feet a little more
Thicken the energy of your being
When's the last time you surrendered to something
without talking yourself up to the task
Buy a fancy sweater, drink a fancy coffee and dance only when
you're alone
Dance only when you're alone?
If a tree only falls in the forest when no one's around
Will it forget
how
When I was a girl my best friend wore her hair up
I wore mine down
I went to a meaningless sporting event last month I don't remember
the sort
But the lad next to me clasped my hand when I clasped his
When I said yes,
he said ya
Crowded world, people everywhere but where is home
Is anyone really looking at me
Would anyone be willing to run with me
To rise with me
for me
Please, I would rave for you
Ask me, ask me I'm itching
for the chance
I cry at every Olympics I don't even have a country
So tired need another coffee
or maybe just a hand in mine
Wherever we're going, don't let me go alone

A SONG FOR ALICE

ROSIE COMFORT

TRIGGER WARNING: EATING DISORDER/MENTAL
HEALTH TRIGGER WARNING.

death on the daily
are the days today and ahead—
just painting the fucking roses red.



as the same record plays on the machine
songs living as a squatter in my head
and after the scratch
i reach for my kindred
hey, let's try and wake from this dream.

ROSIE COMFORT WRITES POEMS
KNOWN TO HAVE DIRT UNDER THEIR
FINGERNAILS AND GLITTER STUCK TO
THEIR BOOTS. WHEN SHE'S NOT
HELPING PEOPLE LEARN TO TAKE THEIR
FIRST STEPS AFTER SURGERY OR GET
STRONGER TO LIVE INDEPENDENTLY AS
A GERIATRIC PHYSICAL THERAPIST,
SHE'S KNOW TO CONJURE POEMS
ABOUT DOLLY PARTON, THE BARBIE
MOVE, AND THE MACHINE WE CALL THE
AMERICAN HEALTHCARE SYSTEM. SHE
LOVES HER SWEET HUSBAND, HER DOG
REDFORD, MOUNTAINS AND
PRETENDING SHE'S A FOOD CRITIC ANY
CHANCE SHE GETS.

oh, there you are, Bailey
let's have a mad tea party.

and i relish the comfort of darkness
the comfort of quiet
the comfort of nothing.

i take attendance before
i bed with my dear friends—

depression.

depression.

depression.

depression.

depression.

depression.
hereherehereherehere.



grief
back again bitch.

anxietyanxietyanxietyanxiety
here or
here or
here or there.

self-hatred
dude I'm FUCKING here you piece of shit.

dISSSSSMoRFeeeeeeUhhhh
ereh.

but today,
today
today
instead of turning in,
a glimmer above catches my eye
i look up
and
fall
fall
fall
through the glass
landing in the limbs of.....



.HER.

looking around...

i've been here.in but a dream?my garden?ouch. it's so bright.deja
oooahhh.there's too much color.

a force of the past?

(a gentle whisper)

present

the tree of life.

...drink in her goodness
her BeYOUtyyy(?)
the strength, ohhh the fierce STRENGTH of her trunk.
trace gentle curves of her branches—
reach and my fingertips relish the softness of her budding fruit.



wake up, love
she breaths
oh, i've been waiting so long for you
i saved you a comfortable seat
and my ear.

(radiant smile)

oh, sing for me, dear heart, like you did when we were but twinkle
twinkle little stars.

(scintillating laughter)

little one, i know you still burn, for you were always the sun.

(her eyes glow and i've seen it before)

you were never small.

i tease a sob of joy(?)
oh, to happen, this was all?

now i think, hm i think. yes.

WE KNOW.

i will live all my days in her aura
with a new record on that she likes.



CATFISH

CATCH

TIME



TESSA MCHATTIE IS A CANADIAN POET RESIDING IN BROOKLYN, NYC. HER POEMS HAVE APPEARED OR ARE FORTHCOMING IN CERASUS MAGAZINE, EUNOIA REVIEW, AND STAR*LINE, AMONG OTHERS.

TESSA MCHATTIE

Gregory, pull a fast one. Rip the hairy honey suckle from the wilting vine. If I'm getting older, let's skip to the part where I regain sexual innocence and the slimy, fermented filth finally crusts and falls. Tell the miser to keep the gold. Today I'll let the dandelions invade my body, penetrate the shell. If only to be perceived as flossy. I'll pretend that choosing the feminine is my very first nature and eagerly swim to my sisters on the shore. Where diamond rings splinter and icy snowflakes abound. I want you to tell me my eyes aren't brown, they're instant cofee. Immediately yours when you are wan, unable to sleep again, grimacing through another dawn.



THE

SARAH RAYBOULD

INSTAGRAM:
RAYBOULD_SARAH
X: @RAYBOULD_DRS
BLUESKY:
@SARAHRAYBOULD.BSK
Y.SOCIAL

CRABS

ARE

COMING



Somewhere between the froth and the jawline of the rock,
there is a riot of orange, jet, beige, egg-yellow crowns
at
bottle neck, spewing shell-legs. It makes no sense I tell
my brain. The bench next to me is empty, warm from
where you left so much chaos. Crabs inch closer,
they swell, click like counterfeit percussion, monsters
in sunset armour. The shoreline has vanished, left only
the flotsam and rind of yesterday's conversations
pinched
and matted with plastic rope ends. There is nowhere to
hide.
They are marching, crustacean foot soldiers click-
clacking
over cobblestone objections. I am unsealed, bait
on a desert beech, frayed in all the wrong places. I try
to
build a cage from the plastic tops and broken shells,
tie it all together the way I've seen the lobster men do.
Perhaps I might crouch inside, be a little protected, but
my layers are coming undone, my heart held high
beating in time with their drum.

